

Session 11: Sea Crossing

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew phrase *yam suph*, often translated as “Red Sea,” translates literally to “reed sea.”
- When the number of Israelites crossing the sea is translated as “600,000 men” plus families, it creates challenges with other parts of the text.
- There are a variety of views that attempt to harmonize the exodus account in the Bible with other biblical evidence and the archaeological record.

What Body of Water Did the Israelites Cross?

- Hebrew: *yam suph* = “Sea of Reeds”
- Greek translation: *eruthran thalassan* = “Red Sea”
- Both “gulfs,” the Gulf of Suez and the Gulf of Aqaba, were *yam suph*
- Some scholars think it became the “red” sea because each of the cardinal directions (north, south, east, and west) was associated with a color (Black Sea is north, Red Sea is south, etc.) From [Smithsonian Journeys](#).
- First mention of the Sea of Reeds: [Exodus 10:19](#); [13:18](#); [15:4](#); [15:22](#); [23:31](#) (e.g., [1 Kings 9:26](#) shows that Ezion-geber is on the shore of *yam suph*, too)

Sea of Reeds in the Literary Design of Exodus

The Hebrew name Sea of Reeds forges an important connection with the deliverance story of the infant Moses, whose mother placed him among the “reeds” in the Nile, and whose name means “one who draws out.”

Just as Moses passed through the reeds to escape death by Pharaoh’s hand, so the Israelites passed through the Sea of Reeds to escape death by Pharaoh’s hand.

How Many Hebrews Left Egypt?

English translations say “600,000 men” plus families ([Exod. 12:37](#)), but this translation creates some historical challenges.

That would likely mean over 2 million Israelites total, however, the archaeological record doesn’t show evidence for this size of population, in either Egypt or Canaan at that time. Furthermore, how could 12 brothers become 600,000 men in four generations ([Exod. 6:14-25](#))?

Other logistical problems arise when considering the size of the camp and the length of time needed to cross the Sea of Reeds.

Making Sense of the Numbers

There are several options for reconciling this verse with the historical record.

- Archaeologists could be wrong, and the 600,000 number is correct.
- The numbers are rhetorical or symbolic.
 - Numbers multiplied by 10 for rhetorical reasons (Allen, 1990). This accounts for round numbers that fit with the exact number of firstborns in relation to the Levites.
 - Numbers represent the population during a later period (Fretheim, 1991). This is a way of affirming that later Israelites were participants in the exodus event.
- The phrase is mistranslated and should read “600 military units” plus families.

Translating ‘Eleph

Hebrew does not use numerals, but instead spells out numbers in full. כֶּשֶׁש־מֵאוֹת אֶלֶף = Six hundred אֶלֶף (‘eleph) on foot, men without children.

The word ‘eleph has four possible meanings in a Hebrew lexicon.

1. Thousand
2. Head of cattle
3. Military unit
4. Clan (tribal unit smaller than a tribe)

Judges 6:15 NRSV*

"But sir, how can I deliver Israel? My אֶלֶף is the weakest in Manasseh, and I am the least in my family."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 22:14 NRSV*

And with him ten chiefs, one from each of the tribal families of Israel, every one of them the head of a family among the אֶלֶף of Israel.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reflection Question

Summarize the different views for interpreting the number (600,000) of Israelite men leaving Egypt in Exodus 12:37.